In Week 7, I explored Phil Agre's Critical Technical Practice (CTP) and Donald Schön's reflective practice. Both of these approaches challenge traditional design methods and can complement each other. However, I find CTP more useful for exposing presuppositions and centring overlooked perspectives.

CTP examines core metaphors, assumptions and underlying ways of thinking. For example a traditional approach may assume a conversational prompt has one correct response, while CTP considers diverse interpretations, making room for different judgements and using disagreements as informative data. Through continuous reflections, designers can consider the viewpoints of marginalised groups and uncover absent representations.

Schön's reflective practice focuses more on setting a problem than solving it, rather than applying established technical theory to defined problems. Effective problem framing can expose embedded socioeconomic values within algorithms, such as the UK's COVID exam-grading algorithm which reinforced systematic inequalities by putting weight on historical data.

While Schön's approach strengthens initial problem framing, I prefer CTP because it continuously considers marginalised groups and integrates their perspectives. However, any design can benefit from combining both approaches, but CTP directly forces the designer to reflect.

https://blogs.ed.ac.uk/s2979870_informatics-1---critical-skills-and-practice-2026-2027sem1/2026/11/03/week-7/